

Representative of the Agency for the Protection of Personal Data participated in the panel "The Impact of the Digital Environment on Children" as part of the professional conference "Protecting Children in the Digital Age," held on October 3 in Split, organized by the Ombudsman for Children and the Split-Dalmatia County.

The increasing number of violations of children's rights in their free time, especially in the digital environment, points to the necessity for greater engagement of adults in this segment of children's lives, as well as the improvement of their protection in the online environment, which was discussed at the professional conference.

The panel "The Impact of the Digital Environment on Children" provided an opportunity to discuss the possible consequences of sharing children's personal data on the internet and how to protect their privacy. Anamarija Mladinić, the head of the Sector for EU, International Cooperation, and Legal Affairs, emphasized that both adults and children are not sufficiently educated about the importance of protecting personal data, particularly in the online environment. "Parents themselves are often unaware of the consequences of careless sharing and public disclosure of personal data, frequently exposing their children to unnecessary dangers by posting their personal information on social media, putting them at risk of abuse, humiliation, cyberbullying, sexual harassment, and exposing them to online predators," said Anamarija Mladinić, warning that a recent European Commission study showed that Croatia, specifically young people aged 18-24, is among the top 10 countries with the lowest level of awareness regarding data protection and the rights and protections provided by the General Data Protection Regulation.

"Children, as well as adults, need to be educated on how to protect their personal data in the online environment, to familiarize them with the dangers and risks associated with careless handling of personal data." She also reminded that the General Data Protection Regulation stipulates that children deserve special protection regarding their personal data because they may be less aware of the risks, consequences, and relevant protective measures, as well as their rights concerning the processing of personal data. "In today's digital age, it is crucial for all of us to be media literate so that we can distinguish true information from misinformation and deepfakes, and just as we take care of our personal hygiene, we must also take care of our cyber hygiene. Just as we care for our identity in real life, we must also care for our virtual identity, which we create with every mouse click and every post on the internet," concluded the head of the Sector.

Additionally, Anita Matijević from the Ministry of the Interior and Ivana Šimetin from the Public Health Institute also participated in the panel "The Impact of the Digital Environment on Children."

By the way, from October 2 to 8, Children's Week is celebrated, and by holding this Conference, which included representatives from state and public services as well as non-governmental organizations, emphasis was placed on the need to protect children and their safety in the digital environment.